

Final Synthesis Paper

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Introduction

Mutual-Aid Disaster Relief (MADR) describes itself as “a decentralized network across the so-called United States, defined by the character and creativity of a multitude of communities and drawn together by our collective commitment to stand in solidarity with those impacted by disasters” (MADR, 2023a). Despite its legal formation as a 501c3 non-profit corporation, MADR’s operational structure, decision-making systems, and aid practices diverge significantly from traditional, top-down aid organizations. Unlike large-scale organizations that operate within strict bureaucratic frameworks, MADR emphasizes a “horizontal, multidimensional and multidirectional process” (MADR, 2023b) – a process grounded in the principles of self-determination, autonomous direct action, intersectionality, sustainability, dual power, and collective liberation (MADR, 2023c).

These guiding principles are fundamentally opposed to traditional models of disaster relief, where decision-making authority is centralized, and aid is prescribed from afar. Rather than viewing disaster survivors as passive recipients of aid, MADR sees these individuals as a valuable resource and the architects of their own recovery. In this sense, MADR’s services, unlike a traditional non-profit, are as varied as the individuals and circumstances where they are needed. Ultimately, this leads to aid being provided with, not for, those in need.

Observations and Insights

Developed and described by John Lederach in *Preparing for Peace: Conflict Transformation Across Cultures*, the Elicitive Training Model seeks to refocus the source of solutions from a practitioner's experience to knowledge already present within a community (see Figure 1). "Culture, in other words, natural and taken-for-granted knowledge in a given setting, is understood as the foundation and seedbed of model development and creation" (Lederach, 2008, p. 62). My practicum approach has been guided by this elicitive model.

As a decentralized organization, Mutual Aid Disaster Relief does not have 'managers' or an HR department. In fact, it is entirely volunteer run with no salaries or board stipends paid. In many ways, participants are expected to act with autonomy and curiosity while they discover 'natural and taken-for-granted knowledge' in real time. From a traditional standpoint, this decentralized, autonomous approach has not seemed an efficient way to integrate a new volunteer, especially one working with financial information. Yet, as I have moved through the Elicitive Model – *discovering, describing, evaluating, and now modeling* (Lederach, 2008, p. 59), the organizational culture and my place within it has become more intuitive. As I seek to communicate my experience, I aim to synthesize my first cycle around the Elicitive Model with another of Lederach's models, the Transformational Platform (see Figure 2).

Combining these models translates to an iterative, elicitive approach – episodically allowing for adaptation to changing circumstances while also integrating lessons learned from the application of theory. However, these concepts are not just useful when evaluating my learning but also elucidate important aspects of how the organization engages with local communities.

In researching additional theories applicable to MADR's aid model, many different concepts rose to the surface. Local ownership, subsidiarity, and social justice all seem to capture elements of locally-driven solutions to local problems – acknowledging that community members are the primary resource in identifying the needs of that community. However, again I turn to a synthesis of theories to best capture the rich transformation taking place in areas affected by disaster through MADR's unique aid model. In conjunction with reflective decision-making structures, MADR's aid model itself also emulates the iterative, elicitive approach outlined above as a synthesis of Lederach's Elicitive Model and Transformational Platform.

It is important to appreciate that this aid work happens at a critical point in time where structural violence can turn direct – when amplified by natural disaster. Through Galtung's Conflict Triangle (see Figure 3) and related theories on conflict, one can begin to see the potential revolutionary impact that an organization like MADR can facilitate. MADR shares in their Guiding Principles:

We recognize that disasters are times of localized upheaval and suffering, but are also opportunities for the rich and powerful to consolidate power and to take advantage of shocks in order to institute economic reforms that further reinforce their privileged status. We oppose this disaster capitalism and affirm our commitment to environmental, social, economic, and climate justice. Instead, we see the sense of community and mutual aid that develops in the wake of crisis as fertile ground to merge social movement theory and praxis by supporting and enabling community members to help themselves and each other. (MADR, 2023b)

These principles exemplify an organizational understanding of the latent violence within structural components of society. MADR acknowledges the threat of direct violence manifesting (localized upheaval) and aims to prevent both ‘disaster capitalism’ and community suffering with one tool, empowering survivors. The primary methodology boils down to reimbursing local activists and community organizations for purchases made in response to disaster. At its best, MADR cultivates long-term relationships with local communities that have evolved into an ever-widening network of individuals assisting one another in the face of global polycrisis. Furthermore, the members of MADR consistently reevaluate this work through working group discussions, proposal evaluations, and internal education systems. This direct, locally

centered aid work, which undergoes reflective analysis, mirrors my approach to learning how to utilize my resources in service to the organization itself, a methodology reflected in Lederach's models of praxis and conflict transformation.

Practice Reflections

In my short time working more in depth with Mutual Aid Disaster Relief, I have taken on many new responsibilities and attended numerous working group meetings. As a member of the accounting working group, I assist our team of three in categorizing, reimbursing, and documenting transactions. Having also worked on the organization's annual 990 tax form for the past few years, I entered my practicum with what I thought was a solid "big picture" view of the organization. However, my assumptions proved incorrect on many occasions:

Table 1

Current Understandings vs Previous Assumptions

Previous Assumption	Current Understanding
One person will train me on systems	Knowledge of systems is spread across many people and working groups (WG)
The QuickBooks file needs organized	The QuickBooks file is a product of consensus decisions on projects/programs among WGs
Flowcharts or other systems should be developed for reimbursements	Reimbursements, while commonly similar, are unique and primarily require mission-alignment
My learning will be prescribed	My learning is self-directed

I will be working specifically on financial data management	I am working on numerous things, plugging into multiple WGs and assisting wherever my skills align
Transparency systems will reduce infighting to a large degree	Transparency, while a problem, is just one of many intra-organizational conflicts
I will work on the exterior, only helping a small amount	I am now involved in the Core WG helping folks to decide on organization-wide issues, trajectories

source: Field Notes from Mutual Aid Disaster Relief Practicum by Hepker, S, 2024

Upon reflection of these shifts in my understanding, a clear pattern emerges, one where my experience working in more traditional organizations has encultured me to expect both the benefits of clarity a top-down organization can offer along with its pitfalls. However, albeit with a bit of frustration, my assumptions were repeatedly challenged, and adaptation has been ongoing. For aspects of the position – such as my training, learning plan, and role – the flexibility offered by the horizontal, decentralized model was initially very overwhelming. Not having a clear leader or rigid policy to refer to left me feeling somewhat lost – having to carve out my own role and guide my own training on how to be most effective. I also assumed that role would be limited and that I would be impactful only on the margins. That assumption has also been proven false as I become more deeply immersed into the Core, Admin, Fundraising, Emails, and General Working Groups – all in service to adding context to my role in accounting by deepening my understanding of how decentralized organizations operate.

In a discussion with my site supervisor, I analogized my experience to an animal being released into the wild from a form of hierarchical captivity. Often animals are rehabilitated from injury or being released from captivity for the first time, a rehab organization will work with them on wild foraging, socialization, and survival skills to provide the best chance at thriving within their newfound freedom. My site supervisor and I discussed that equivalent structures – meant to support an individual's orientation within a decentralized model – seem to be lacking. Luckily, I have previous experience with cooperative models, consensus–decision making, and open books accounting. Still, even in combination with the Peace and Conflict Studies curriculum, my experience has not insulated me from making many mistakes.

Uniquely, there is a lot of space at MADR for individuals to learn and grow from misunderstandings, mistakes, and incorrect assumptions. Everyone at MADR engages in their work from a place of care. Compassion, administrative support, validation, and community have been made available to me in limitless quantities since my first day. There is an understanding from long-term members that MADR is also where activists learn to organize. In continuing to develop my understanding of MADR's model and my role within it, I feel progressively more comfortable defining my role and adding my skillset to the collective's toolkit. At the same time, I hope to identify a model which can benefit the cultivation of academic theory to explore MADR's aid praxis more fully.

Elicitive Aid

To explore and model MADR's unique organizational structure and aid praxis more deeply, we must first give it a name. For now, *Elicitive Aid* can serve to capture both the spirit of survivor-led disaster recovery while also highlighting the precedent set by Lederach's elicitive approach and other forms of participatory action. In the wake of hurricane Helene, a unique opportunity exists to map the organizational response, with special focus to how decentralization works in practice throughout the course of a disaster – a disaster which in many ways is still ongoing. To see the evolution of the response, it helps to examine the organization's evolving structure during three temporal stages: the immediate response before and shortly after the disaster, then a few weeks into recovery when internet and cell service return, and finally the long-term organizing that follows for years (see Figure 4).

In the days preceding Helene's landfall, MADR chats began to come to life while at the same time, proactive donations started to slowly trickle in. Some members of the organization posted weather updates and projected path models on a regular basis. Infrastructure like the gasoline distribution and solar charging trailers were readied for deployment. MADR's network of over 300 individuals across the USA began to activate and started checking in with existing contacts and organizations in regions where impacts were expected to be the worst. Still, I don't think anyone was prepared

for just how bad the disaster would be in Western North Carolina (WNC). On September 27th, 2024, rivers and creeks all over the region swelled to record heights, sweeping away homes, depositing hazardous waste along the banks, and destroying roadways, water, and electrical infrastructure. As we enter the coldest months of the year, many are still without power and clean drinking water.

From September 28th to date over a million dollars has been donated to MADR, mostly in the form of individual donations of \$20 or less (though Yoko Ono did generously provide a donation of \$10k). The effects of this newfound financial capacity on the organizational culture are profound and ongoing. Exploring those effects is a continuing process and, though it deserves its own analysis, is outside the scope of this paper. Despite finding themselves in a novel financial position, individuals outside of the immediate disaster area coordinated to develop systems in real time to manage the response – in the same way they had done many times before. These included volunteer vetting, reimbursement process training, dispatch setup, mapping distribution site locations, and processing a growing list of individuals needing critical assistance. A regional chat was created specifically for Helene response and resources were consolidated into that channel, which quickly grew to over 150 people working on immediate response. For the first few weeks, individuals from all over the United States were coordinated, reimbursed for supplies, provided travel authorization forms, and

connected with on-the-ground volunteers to receive the incoming donations. These workflows continued for weeks but quickly became cumbersome and obsolete when power and cell service began to return to the affected regions. At that point, the primary logistical operations began to shift to local hubs and individuals in the field.

Roughly three months into the response, remote volunteers have been doing far less coordination of direct aid, instead shifting focus to developing internal structures to optimize getting local organizers the resources they need. This can be seen in its most basic form in the shift from purchasing critical supplies like gasoline and groceries to infrastructure supplies like shelving and pallet jacks. Empowered by the financial resources of a national network and the inherent efficiency of their own local wisdom, existing community organizations are now well adapted to their new roles of warehousing supplies, fielding aid requests, and coordinating volunteers and deliveries. Reliable reimbursement systems are being utilized daily to allow these organizations to supplement donations, not only meet the immediate needs of their communities, but also to build their own resilience. For example, Rural Organizing and Resilience (ROAR) was able to purchase a 4x4 ATV, enabling their organization to deliver supplies to remote areas in the mountains. This vehicle will also be utilized in the coming months as part of ROAR's existing firewood distribution program.

Ultimately, MADR is made up of individuals who once were responding to their own local disaster. MADR was shaped by hurricanes Katrina, Sandy, and now Helene. As MADR's role shifts yet again to supporting long-term recovery and resilience, what remains in the wake of the flood damage is a newly formed network of local mutual aid hubs. The Smith-Mill warehouse in Asheville, the ROAR distribution center in Marshall, and the Triangle Mutual Aid hub in Chapel Hill, all profoundly more organized and well equipped now than before. MADR has extended an invitation to everyone involved in the Helene response to take part in the annual Participatory Budgeting process planned for early 2025. My work recently has been focused on developing a project proposal form. The form aims to be both adequately descriptive and accessible to everyone who wants to bring a large infrastructure project for their community to the budgeting meeting. As these local organizations increase their capacity, they will be able to inspire and guide new projects in their immediate area – extending the network.

Returning to Figure 4, what is important to highlight, in addition to a growing network, is the transfer of power from the central organization to the local hubs. Elicitive Aid is fundamentally opposed to prescribing aid from afar. Remote volunteers, despite their decades of experience in disaster organizing, only guided local aid in the immediate aftermath of the storm. According to Elicitive Aid, coordinating an insulin delivery from 400 miles away, for someone you don't know, who lives in a town you

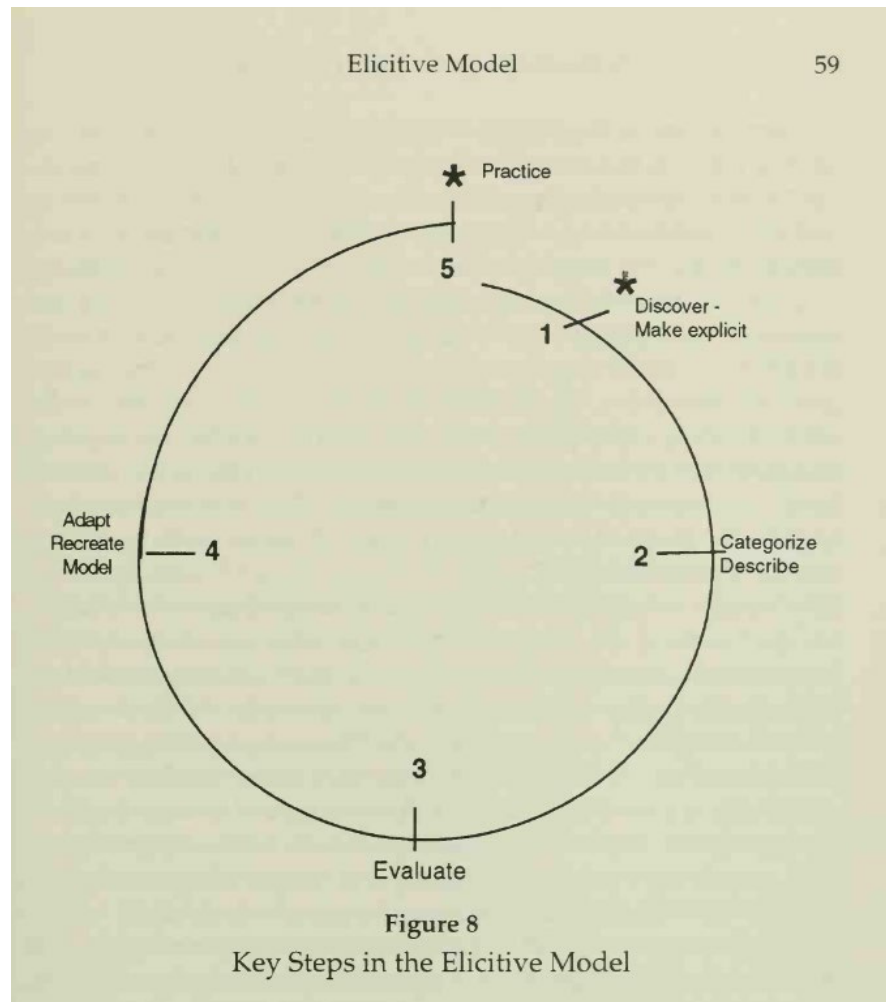
can't pronounce the name of, is woefully inefficient. Elicitive Aid is not wedded to a one-size-fits-all toolkit or systems that are enshrined at the national level. It is flexible and adaptable to the philosophies of the local culture. This all but eliminates bureaucracy and barriers to aid access, ultimately facilitating agile and efficient response. Elicitive Aid is also holistic and seeks to co-create resiliency. It pushes back on systemic inequity by uplifting communities to create systems that reflect their needs in the short and long term. It is an active decentralization that sets an intention to transfer power from high to low concentrations and ensures that all voices are heard, especially those voices who have been historically quieted. At its best, Elicitive Aid can see a disaster zone as fertile soil for the growth of community connection that minimizes the latent structural and cultural violence in that region. Where the generosity of donors and volunteer organizers can be transformed into the sunlight, water, and nutrients needed to foster a community ready to face the next storm together.

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Appendix

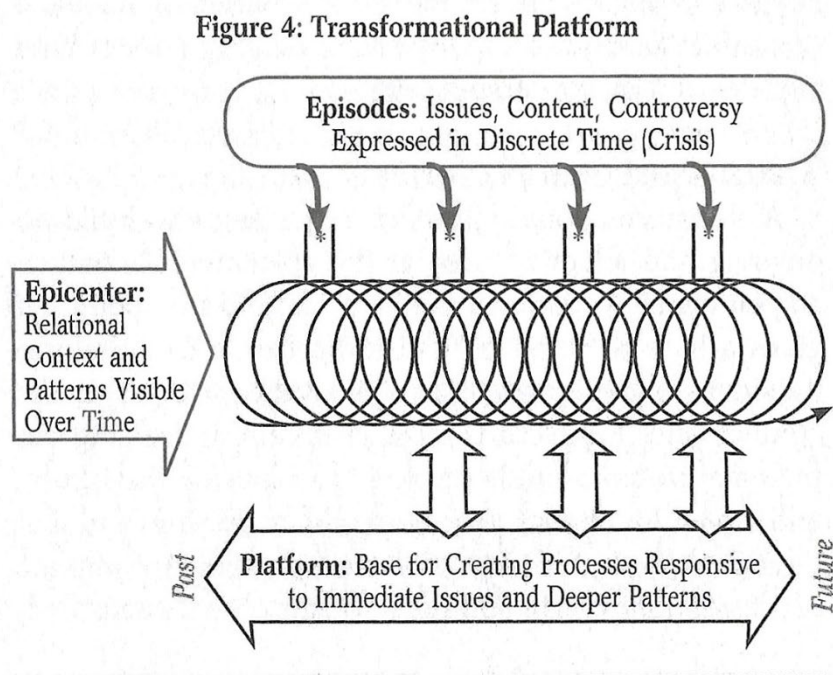
Figure 1:



John Lederach (2008). Retrieved from:

Lederach, J. P. (2008). *Preparing For Peace: Conflict Transformation Across Cultures*. Syracuse Univ. Press.

Figure 2:



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Figure 3:

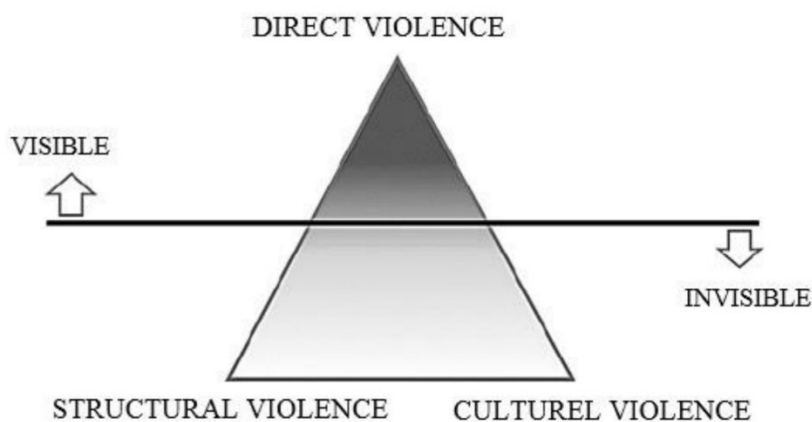


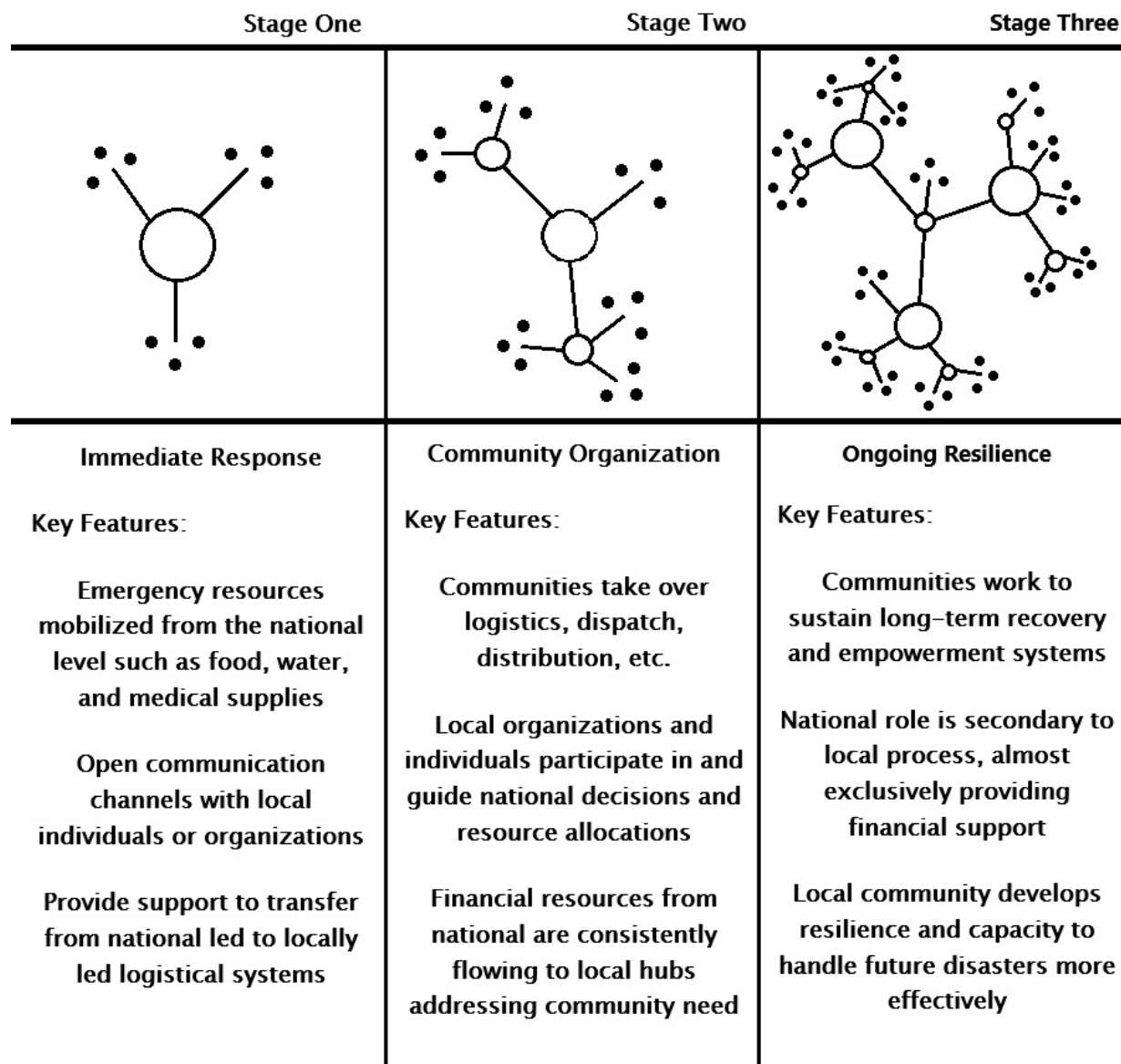
Figure 1. Galtung's Violent Triangle Model

Source: Galtung (1990, p. 295)

Johan Galtung (1990). Retrieved from:

<https://dergipark.org.tr/en/download/article-file/1282610>

Figure 4:



Sprout Hepker (2024). Retrieved From:

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